“Strong people don't show emotion.”

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Where it often comes from

Families, sports, the military, workplaces, and some churches praise those who “keep it together.” Boys especially hear “Don’t cry.” We learn to bottle feelings, which then leak out as anger, numbness, or physical tension.

What Scripture teaches

“Jesus wept.” Isaiah calls Him “a man of sorrows, acquainted with grief.” Paul says, “Rejoice with those who rejoice; weep with those who weep.” David wrote, “I am weary from groaning; all night I flood my bed with weeping.” Paul also says, “when I am weak, then I am strong.” The Lord who is strongest shows emotion. Strength is not the absence of feeling. It is facing feeling honestly and bringing it to God and to safe people.

> *“Jesus wept”* (John 11:35).

Also see

> “He was despised and rejected by men, a man of sorrows, acquainted with grief. Like one from whom men hide their faces, He was despised, and we esteemed Him not” (Isaiah 53:3).

> “Rejoice with those who rejoice; weep with those who weep” (Romans 12:15).

> “I am weary from groaning; all night I flood my bed with weeping and drench my couch with tears” (Psalm 6:6).

> “But He said to me, ‘My grace is sufficient for you, for My power is perfected in weakness.’ Therefore I will boast all the more gladly in my weaknesses, so that the power of Christ may rest on me. That is why, for the sake of Christ, I delight in weaknesses, in insults, in hardships, in persecutions, in difficulties. For when I am weak, then I am strong” (2 Corinthians 12:9–10).

Common self-statements

- Tears are weakness.
- I have to hold it together.
- Feelings get in the way.
- I should not need anyone.
- Showing emotion makes me a burden.
- I will fall apart if I let it out.

Common logical errors

- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing I am either composed or weak.
- Mind reading: Assuming people would think less of me.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling vulnerable and concluding that it is dangerous.
- Fortune telling: Predicting I will lose control.

Challenging questions

- Who taught me that feelings are weakness?
- How did Jesus show emotion?
- What happens to the feelings I hold in?

- Who is safe enough to share with?
- What would a friend say to someone who felt this way?
- What is one feeling I could name this week?

Truth summary

> Emotions are part of how God made me. Jesus wept, and strength includes honesty. I can name my feelings, bring them to God, and share them with safe people.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Depression, Symptoms of
- Suffering
- Confession
- Weakness
- Hardship

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Divorce
- Forgive/Forgiveness

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Just Be Held — Casting Crowns
God's care remains when control, strength, or explanations run out.

Praise You in This Storm — Casting Crowns featuring Phil Wickham
Suffering and tears do not establish that God is absent or uncaring.

I Am Not Alone — Kari Jobe
God's companionship remains through darkness, weakness, and uncertainty.

Blessed Assurance — Larry Ford and Lillie Knauls with Gaither
This classic hymn celebrates belonging to Christ and resting in His salvation.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "Strong people don't show emotion"

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"Strong people don't show emotion." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ Who taught me this?
- ☐ How did Jesus show emotion?
- ☐ What happens to held-in feelings?
- ☐ Who is safe?
- ☐ What would I tell a friend?
- ☐ What can I name?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ Jesus wept.
- ☐ The Savior was acquainted with grief.
- ☐ David poured out his tears to God.
- ☐ In weakness I am strong.
- ☐ Feelings are part of how God made me.
- ☐ Safe people can help me carry them.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ John 11:35
  "Jesus wept."
- ☐ Romans 12:15
  "Rejoice with those who rejoice; weep with those who weep."
- ☐ 2 Corinthians 12:9–10
  "But He said to me, 'My grace is sufficient for you, for My power is perfected in weakness.' Therefore I will boast all the more gladly in my weaknesses, so that the power of Christ may rest on me. That is why, for the sake of Christ, I delight in weaknesses, in insults, in hardships, in persecutions, in difficulties. For when I am weak, then I am strong."

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] Named feelings: Each day, name one feeling and tell God about it.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, John 11:35 becomes: "Sarah can write: "Jesus wept, so my feelings are not weakness.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Suffering" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- [ ] Name what you feel. Write one feeling a day.
- [ ] Read the Psalms. Notice how David expresses emotion.
- [ ] Share with one person. Pick someone safe.
- [ ] Move or breathe. Release tension through a walk or slow breathing.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "Strong people don't show emotion": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	Named feelings
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~Strong people don't show emotion.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord Jesus, You wept. Teach me that strength includes honesty. Help me bring my feelings to You and to safe people. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.